

NATION INDIAN MUSLIMS

Muslim males with their burqa-clad women in multiplexes and roaming about in malls located in Hindu areas. This freedom indicates their reality in the country as against the image of their being under a siege.

The Muslims do feel scared of the communal agenda of the BJP and the RSS but it still can't be said that this agenda is fuelling the terror we have seen in recent years. We can't deny that terrorism is a world phenomenon but it is difficult to say that the factors fuelling terrorism in India are same or different. Pakistan is certainly behind the radicalisation of this small number that has taken to terrorism in India. It can't happen without Pakistan's involvement.

Then there are some puritanical Islamic *tanzeems* that are spreading thoughts based on puritanical interpretation of religion, but I don't think they are preaching terrorism. Rather, their puritanical thoughts are proving useful to terror outfits to attract a small section of Muslim youth. But, despite the provocations, India's composite culture will prevail. Common Muslims are rooted in this land. **As told to Uday Mahurkar**



“ONE CAN EASILY FIND TOPI-CLAD MUSLIM MALES WITH THEIR BURQA-CLAD WOMEN ROAMING IN MALLS IN HINDU AREAS.”



SAMINA MISHRA
Documentary filmmaker

How does one speak of the diversity of being Indian when Diwali is celebrated in schools and Id just in Muslim homes?

Jamia Nagar is one of my homes. Not very far from L-18, in the posh part of Jamia, there is a house on a tree-lined avenue that will always be home to me. But my life, with its easy privileges, could not be more different from Atif and Sajid's, the two young men shot as alleged terrorists at L-18. It contains multitudes, Whitman so eloquently said. But we live in a time when even multitudes are forced to lay claim to a singular label. And so by writing this, perhaps, I will now forever be labelled as the voice of the liberal secular Muslim, a voice that the cacoph-

ony on a popular Internet list claims does not speak up or speak up enough. But is it not the tyranny of labels that grants me this space in a mainstream national magazine?

As someone with a Muslim first name and a surname that is a Hindu caste name, I suppose I have always swung between labels—a poster girl for communal harmony or a confused, rootless individual with no loyalties, depending on who was doing the labelling. I went to a public school and I do not wear a burqa. I just might escape being thrown into the big cauldron with “Islamic terrorists”. But I will certainly be put aside in the one for “misguided intellectuals”. And while there is no mistaking that it is zealous nationalists who seek to light the fire under the first cauldron, the other is a bone of contention between those who seek to define for me how to be Indian and those who seek to define for me how to be Muslim. My condemnation of the Babri Masjid demolition or Imrana's rape or the media circus around Gudiya will always be seen in the context of my privileged background, my gender, my religious identity. Perhaps, it can be no other way.

But when my civil marriage to a non-Muslim is interpreted variously as a rejection of Islam or an embracing of Hinduism or a sign of India's “composite culture”, then what is it that is really being stifled? In this rhetoric of binaries, of “us and them”, it is difficult to find the space to create a new paradigm of discussion. And so, in